

Current Status

This guideline was published in 2019 and amended in 2024 to take account of [SIGN 245](#), developed by the British Thoracic Society (BTS), the National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) and SIGN. Sections on non-pharmacological management, occupational management and difficult and severe asthma are under review. Details can be found in the scoping summary. Updates to the guideline in the interim period, will be noted in the update report.

 **IMPORTANT** 

In April 2025 the MHRA issued a reminder of the risk of severe asthma attacks and increased mortality associated with overuse of SABA with or without anti-inflammatory maintenance therapy in patients with asthma.

Further information is available from: [Short-acting beta 2 agonists \(SABA\) \(salbutamol and terbutaline\): reminder of the risks from overuse in asthma and to be aware of changes in the SABA prescribing guidelines](#)

Summary

This guideline focuses on the management of adults, including pregnant women, and adolescents and children with asthma, including:

- non-pharmacological management
- difficult and severe asthma
- management of acute asthma
- asthma in pregnancy
- occupational asthma.

Diagnosis, monitoring and chronic asthma management is covered in [SIGN 245 Asthma: diagnosis, monitoring and chronic asthma management](#), developed by the British Thoracic Society (BTS), the National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) and SIGN.

The guideline is part of the asthma pathway, developed by BTS, NICE and SIGN, which links to tools, resources and information, and has been designed to support healthcare professionals in making accurate diagnoses, promoting good practice, and providing effective, personalised treatment to control and prevent acute asthma attacks.

Who it’s for

The guideline will be of interest to healthcare professionals involved in the care of people with asthma including:

- general practitioners
- consultants and specialists in respiratory medicine
- nurses
- pharmacists and other allied health professionals with an interest in respiratory care.

The guideline will also be of interest to people with asthma, their parents and carers; those who interact with people with asthma outside of the NHS, such as teachers; voluntary organisations with an interest in asthma; and those planning the delivery of services in the NHS in Scotland, England, Wales and Northern Ireland.

We will also be updating our plain language booklet for patients, families and carers covering:

- asthma in adults
- asthma in children
- asthma in pregnancy

How this guideline was developed

The original guideline was developed using a standard methodology based on a systematic review of the evidence. Further details can be found in [SIGN 50: A Guideline Developer’s Handbook](#).

Amendments were made in May 2025 to sections 3 (pack-years) and 9 (life-threatening asthma criteria).

 Current < 3 years